



BY AMIT CHANDRA

India's Mantra Should be Equitable Growth

India has to eliminate poverty, be inclusive, and sustainable in the next 25 years. Given its history, it can certainly achieve this feat

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MANY DOUBTED WHETHER our country would even survive a decade when we gained independence. At various points in our journey since, we came close to the brink—both economically and geopolitically. Today, India@75 is a nation that stands tall, is a voice that is heard and counted on the global political stage, and importantly, is one amongst a handful that has a positive trajectory on most counts. Therefore, as I think of my vision for India@100, as a follower of Guru Nanak, I invoke the prayer: *Nanak naam chardi kala, tere bhane sarbat da bhallā*. What does this mean and what does it have to do with my dream for India@100?

I have little doubt that our

country will continue to grow over the coming 25 years. The debate needs to be centred on how robustly and what can be done to accelerate the growth? If we grow at around 6 per cent, impressive in the long term on a larger base, we will be a \$25-trillion-plus economy (in market exchange rate terms) by 2047. This is where we need *Chardi Kala*—boosting GDP growth by 0.5 per cent will mean adding a number equivalent to the current GDP per capita by 2047! There is simply no more powerful way for us to fight and eliminate the scourge of poverty, and bring prosperity to our middle class than by boosting growth, especially doing so equitably.

I believe much of the foundation to achieve this has been laid, while we need to continue to walk the difficult path on some decisions to their logical conclusions. By India@100, to add hundreds of millions of jobs, we will need to massively improve the competitiveness of our manufacturing sector and make it far easier to do business across all segments of the economy. Many of the government's initiatives over the past decade are paying dividends now. However, there is a need

to fine tune them, rather than finding new ones, and that should be the key mantra. Simultaneously, much of the emphasis to achieve success will now shift on states driving execution, and again the framework for that is being laid down.

There are three more issues we will have to relentlessly push at the macro level: firstly, focussing on reducing our energy and fertiliser imports/subsidy in mission mode. Our experience over the past few decades shows that we remain very vulnerable to imported shocks on this account, and the subsidy burden gets passed on via high rates that costs the economy dearly. Investing to drive changes in these areas will be both an imperative and can unleash huge opportunities. Secondly, embedding innovation, science, and technology much more deeply into our ecosystem. We must find ways of materially upping our investments in these areas and cutting obstacles that impede them. An India which will be a leader in these areas will not only transform the lives of a billion-plus of its citizens, but also be a cradle for the same, all over the world. Thirdly, we need a huge emphasis on strengthening the MSME